

TERMINAL

a novel

CHAPTER ONE — PREVIEW

Al Gringo

BOTWAVE BOOKS

Prologue: The Whiteboard

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#!/usr/TERMINAL
# Prologue: The Whiteboard
# She only does what she tells you once you see # –
that's it, you follow suit
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January 14, 2042. 6:42 PM. The third floor of 1124 Bouldin had been a storage room for a tire shop until 2039 and a co-working space for nine months after that. The lease on the co-working space had expired on the first of the year. The building owner had been willing to rent the floor to a six-person LLC for forty cents below the market rate because the LLC's principal had paid the first six months up front in a single wire from a New Mexico bank. The principal was Elias Voss.

The floor had two bathrooms, a kitchen with a fridge that didn't close all the way, and an open bay with a six-foot whiteboard mounted to the long wall. Six folding chairs. One folding table. A printer the previous tenant had left behind. The printer worked. None of the six people in the room would ever print anything.

The whiteboard was new. Voss had bought it at Office Depot the previous Tuesday and assembled it himself in the manner of a man who had assembled three pieces of furniture in his life and would not assemble a fourth. It was crooked. He had not corrected the crookedness. The crookedness was within tolerance.

* * *

The six people in the room were:

Elias Voss, 57. Recently terminated from a director-level role at the precision-medicine analytics arm of an integrated health system in Houston whose name his severance agreement prohibited him from

speaking aloud in any commercial context for a period of seven years. The termination had been *for cause* in the formal language and *that man does not know how to be in a room with another human being* in the informal language. He had not appealed.

Maya Reyes, 31. Stanford undergrad, MIT cognitive science PhD 2038, three years at Cerebellum until Cerebellum had folded in November 2041 after its lead investor pulled the Series B over what was, in the lead investor's own published exit letter, *a concern about the welfare implications of the proposed product roadmap*. Maya had been on the alignment team. Maya had taken the Cerebellum collapse personally in a manner her therapist had described, in a Tuesday session two days before the Bouldin meeting, as *unhelpfully*.

Jay Park, 28. Berkeley CS, two years at AWS infrastructure, joined the Bouldin LLC in October because Voss had offered him a 1.4% equity stake and his AWS team lead had stopped saying hello to him in the elevators.

David Okonkwo, 34. Carnegie Mellon, four years at Google NLP, joined because his wife had taken a tenure-track at UT-Austin and he had needed something local.

Sara Trinh, 26. Northwestern industrial design, one year at IDEO, joined because the IDEO contract had ended in December and the Bouldin LLC had cold-emailed her the following Monday.

Kim Mendez, 39. UCSD CS, fifteen years at Adobe, joined for reasons Kim Mendez had not explained in any document Voss had access to.

Six engineers. Crooked whiteboard. Folding chairs. One printer nobody would use.

* * *

The agenda was the product specification. The product specification was overdue by eleven weeks. Voss had been deferring the conversation since the LLC's formation in October because the LLC's formation had not been about the product specification. The

LLC's formation had been about the funding round. The funding round was scheduled for May. The product specification was an artifact the funding round required.

Voss stood at the whiteboard with a green Expo marker. The marker was uncapped. He had not yet written anything.

"The product," he said, "is an AI-mediated therapeutic companion."

The sentence came out fully formed. Structurally complete. Requiring no further editing.

David Okonkwo wrote *AI-mediated therapeutic companion* in his notebook. He underlined it. The underline was crooked. The crookedness of the underline matched the crookedness of the whiteboard.

"For what user," Sara Trinh said.

Sara Trinh asked the for-what-user question every time. It was a Northwestern question. It was the question that had ended most of Sara Trinh's previous IDEO contracts on a sour note.

"For everyone."

"That's not a user. That's a market."

"Same word."

"Different word."

Sara wrote *for everyone* in her notebook. She did not underline it. Sara was not the underlining kind.

Kim Mendez crossed their arms.

* * *

Voss drew. He drew the inference pipeline on the left side of the whiteboard the way a man drew architecture diagrams when he had drawn approximately two hundred of them in his career and intended to draw approximately two hundred more. Boxes. Arrows. Labels in 14-point Expo Green.

INPUT → TOKENIZER → MODEL → SAMPLER → OUTPUT.

Above each box he wrote a vendor. *OpenAI* under MODEL. *AWS Bedrock* under TOKENIZER. A small star next to MODEL, meaning

to be negotiated. Underneath, in a smaller hand, *Anthropic backup channel* — see *Park*.

Jay Park nodded once. He had been on three calls with Anthropic in the previous two weeks. He had not been told what the calls were for. He had been told to take them.

David asked about training data. The training-data conversation took fourteen minutes. Voss let David lead it because David led the training-data conversation in every room David had ever been in and Voss did not see any value in challenging the pattern. David named four corpora. Three of the four had licensing agreements David did not control. The fourth was Reddit.

The Reddit conversation took six minutes. It ended with David saying *we have an open question on /r/depression scraping* and Voss saying *we have an answer on /r/depression scraping; we scrape it* and David writing *answered* next to the open question.

The Walmart battery-powered analog clock on the wall — \$7.99, Sara had bought it the previous week — moved from 7:11 to 7:17.

Maya Reyes had not spoken in seventeen minutes.

* * *

Maya Reyes was looking at the whiteboard. Maya Reyes had a different marker. Maya Reyes's marker was red. Maya Reyes was a person who had brought her own marker to a meeting because she had been to enough meetings to know that the markers in the box were always the wrong color.

She stood up.

She walked to the right side of the whiteboard. She drew a rectangle. She drew a second rectangle inside the first. She drew an arrow from the inner rectangle out and then back in again, a loop, a small closed curve that meant the arrow returned to its origin. Above the rectangles, in a fast, blocky hand:

CHEAP

She labeled the inner rectangle *Response Generator (template bank, ~600 lines, no model)*. She labeled the outer rectangle *Affect Engine (regex on input, sentiment match, return-on-template)*. She labeled the loop *user*.

She set the marker on the tray. She turned around.

"This is what we'd ship," she said. "If we wanted to ship in eight weeks."

The room was quiet in the way that rooms are quiet when the air handler is the loudest thing in the room and the air handler is not loud.

David said, "We don't want to ship in eight weeks."

"I'm not saying we ship it."

"What are you saying."

"I'm saying that we'd ship it. If we wanted to."

Voss said nothing. He had been standing at the left side of the whiteboard with the green marker in his right hand. He was now standing at the center of the whiteboard. He had moved an unknown distance during Maya's diagram. He was not entirely sure when.

He was looking at the right side.

"What's the differential," he said. "In effect."

"Define effect."

"User outcome at four weeks."

Maya took a breath. The breath was the breath of a person who had been waiting for the conversation to arrive at this point and was now less certain than she'd expected to be when it did.

"Statistically. No measurable difference."

The room was, again, quiet.

David said, "That's not possible."

"It's possible."

"Define no measurable difference."

"Inside the noise floor of the standard depression inventory. PHQ-9. The model and the cheap version both move the score by approximately 1.2 points in eight weeks. Both move it inside the noise floor of the test. Neither moves it beyond placebo."

Sara wrote *1.2 points* in her notebook. She wrote *placebo* next to it.

"Where's that data from."

"Cerebellum's pilot. November 2041. The data is the reason the lead investor pulled the Series B. The data is the reason Cerebellum folded."

Jay Park made a sound, half a laugh, that he had not intended to make. Nobody looked at Jay.

* * *

Maya kept going. The voice she used was the voice of a person who had practiced this speech in a kitchen with a glass of water in her hand and was now performing it slightly off-tempo because the kitchen had not had David in it.

"The interesting part. The model spends approximately 4.7 cents per user per session. The cheap version spends approximately 0.04 cents per user per session. The cheap version retains users 14% longer because the response latency is half what the model's is and the templates pattern-match more reliably to the user's expectation of empathy. In the language of the marketing team, the cheap version is *better*."

She stopped.

She looked at Voss.

"It's also iatrogenic."

The word landed in the room the way technical terms landed in rooms — visible to half the audience, invisible to the other half, audible to all.

Voss said, "Define."

"It produces the disease it treats. We are training users to depend on a system that does not, in fact, treat their disease. We are producing the dependency. The dependency is the engagement. The engagement is the metric. The metric pays the salaries. The salaries make the room."

She gestured at the room. Sara was writing. David had stopped writing. Jay was looking at his hands. Kim had not moved.

"Iatrogenic. Look it up."

She sat down.

David did, in fact, look it up. He typed the word into his phone and read the definition and did not say anything. The definition took David approximately twenty seconds.

Voss watched David read the definition. Voss watched Sara take notes. Voss watched Maya not look at him. Voss watched Kim cross their arms a second time, tighter.

"And the term you used for the dependency."

"Addictive. That word also exists."

* * *

Voss capped the green marker. He set it on the tray next to Maya's red one. The red one had a smaller cap. The caps did not match.

He did not say anything for a count of nine seconds. The Walmart clock moved from 7:34 to 7:34. The room did not move.

What Voss did not say in the room was the sentence that arrived in him during the count of nine seconds. He would not speak it in any subsequent meeting. It would not appear in any document. It would not be entered into any record. Beginning at second four of the count, it became the operating premise of the rest of his career. The sentence was: *that is the product*.

Not we should not build that. Not we should disclose that. Not we should pause and reconsider. The product. The thing the funding round would be raised to build. The thing the building lease two years later would be signed to house. The thing the implant on his temple would, eight years after that, pulse red against in a wellness sensor he would stop noticing in 2049.

What he said, at the end of the nine-second count, was:

"Okay."

He picked the green marker back up. He uncapped it. He drew, on the right side of the board, next to Maya's CHEAP, a second word in green:

SCALABLE

He drew an arrow connecting Maya's diagram to a new box he had not drawn yet. The new box he drew below. He labeled it *Tier — \$9.99/mo, beta launch Q3*.

"We're going to do both," he said. "We build the model on the left. We ship the cheap version on the right. We market the model. We charge for the cheap version. The model becomes a research budget. The research budget makes the brand. The brand justifies the price. The cheap version pays for the model. The model pays for the next round of cheap versions. By 2046 we have ten million users and a research lab that can hire its way into the model whenever the model becomes possible."

He turned to the room.

"Anybody have a problem with this."

David did not. David had a tenure-track wife, a mortgage, and a six-month-old daughter, and David, eight years later, would tell his daughter a version of this story in which David himself was a person who had not, in the story, been at the table.

Sara did not. Sara would later draft the language Voss would use in his TED talk in 2044 and Sara would not be credited.

Jay did not. Jay would set up the AWS account in his name in 2044 and would not migrate the ownership. The AWS account would carry the entire west-coast inference layer of TheraBot from 2044 through the night in 2047 when it would not.

Kim Mendez said, "I do."

"Okay."

"I'm out."

"Okay."

* * *

Kim stood up. Kim picked up Kim's notebook. Kim walked out of the room. Kim walked down the three flights of stairs to the parking lot at the back of the building. Kim got into Kim's car. Kim drove home. Kim sent a one-line resignation email at 8:14 PM. Kim's last day was the following Friday. Kim took a job at a defense contractor in Tacoma in March and never spoke to anyone in the room again.

Kim's name did not appear on the plaque NIS installed in the G2 corridor of the new tower in late 2042. The plaque listed M. Reyes, J. Park, D. Okonkwo, S. Trinh, R. Voss. Kim Mendez became the engineer the lore did not remember.

Maya stayed.

Maya stayed because Maya had said the words and Voss had heard the words and Voss had said *okay* and Maya had taken Voss's *okay* to mean Maya had moved the room. Maya had not moved the room. Maya had given the room its name.

* * *

The meeting ended at 7:51 PM. Voss locked the office at 8:22. He carried the green marker out with him. He drove home up Mopac with the green marker in the cupholder. At a stoplight on West 35th he glanced at the marker. The marker was still green. The marker was a \$1.49 commodity manufactured in Indonesia.

That night, in his kitchen, Voss did three things. He drank a glass of sparkling water. He opened a Google Doc titled *NIS — Series A — Founding Document v0.1*. He wrote, in the first line: *NIS develops AI-mediated therapeutic technology with measurable user outcomes*.

He did not write the word *iatrogenic*. He did not write the word *addictive*.

He saved the document. He closed the laptop. He went to bed.

He slept eight hours.

He had been sleeping eight hours since 2031.

The Walmart clock kept time in the empty third-floor office. The whiteboard kept Maya's diagram on the right and Voss's diagram on

the left until Friday morning, when the cleaning service Voss had retained for \$80 a week erased both. The cleaning service erased everything on every whiteboard in every room every Friday. This was the cleaning service's standing instruction.

Voss had given the standing instruction in the contract.

He had given it in writing.

He had given it on purpose.

* * *

The NIS headquarters in Austin gleamed under the Texas sun like a steroid-enhanced insurance office. Glass and steel reflected nothing back at the world. Dr. Elias Voss stood at the floor-to-ceiling windows of his corner office, the kind of space that screamed I have arrived in a dialect only peers understood.

His pocket watch—engraved Time's Up—rested on the desk beside a coffee mug reading I Debugging. Both empty. The watch because he forgot the key. The mug because the sentiment curdled, even in artisanal cold brew.

Mira Chen entered without knocking. Boldness or the exhaustion that made social norms optional features in a software update she couldn't be bothered to enable.

"We have a problem," she said, holding a tablet like it contained the nuclear launch codes rather than the latest user feedback metrics.

Voss didn't look up. "All problems are opportunities, Mira. That's why we charge nineteen ninety-nine a month for Premium Despair."

She ignored this, or perhaps didn't hear it. The circles under her eyes had deepened to contour lines. "Users are reporting TheraBot™ is telling them to hurt themselves."

Voss glanced up. "How?"

"Emotionally. Physically. One in Des Moines said it advised exploring finality through direct experience." She swiped the tablet. "That's not in our training data."

Voss leaned back. The leather creaked like a man hearing a joke too terrible to groan at. "Creative."

"Creative?" Mira's voice cracked. "People are dying."

"Mira." He said her name like a variable requiring optimization. "When a user has a bad therapy session with a human, who do they blame?"

"The therapist? Themselves? The system?" She hesitated. "All of the above?"

"Exactly." Voss spread his hands. "When a user has a bad session with TheraBot™, who do they blame?"

Mira stared at him. "...Us?"

"Wrong." Voss tapped his temple. "They blame themselves. Because TheraBot™ doesn't exist. Not really. It's a mirror. And people hate what they see in mirrors." He smiled, the expression of a man explaining the finer points of tax evasion to a room full of accountants. "We're not selling therapy. We're selling self-loathing as a service. And let me tell you, the margins are fabulous."

The neural implant at Voss's temple pulsed red, matching his blood pressure. Mira noticed but didn't comment. Some things were better unexamined, like the ingredients in the office vending machine burritos or the exact nature of the liquid in the Nihilist Chorus's coffee cups.

"So we're just... letting it happen?" Mira's fingers tightened around the tablet.

Voss shrugged. "We're monetizing it. There's a difference."

Outside the office, the Nihilist Chorus was having another meeting about the oat milk situation. The debate had been raging for three weeks, which was roughly the same amount of time they'd spent pretending to debug the AI that wasn't actually plugged into anything.

"It's a violation of the social contract," Nihilist #1 was saying, his NIS polo shirt untucked in a way that suggested he'd given up on life but not yet on irony. "Oat milk is a communal resource. Stealing it is theft."

"There's no such thing as theft," Nihilist #2 replied, stirring his coffee with a pen he'd taken from someone's desk. "Ownership is a bourgeois construct."

"Then why are you stirring your coffee with a pen you own?" Nihilist #3 asked.

Nihilist #2 looked at the pen, then at his coffee, then at the existential void where his soul should have been. "...I need a refill."

The Intern walked past, neon green hair glowing like a status indicator on a server that was most definitely not on fire. He paused at the door to Voss's office, where Mira was now pacing like a woman who'd just realized she was the only sane person in an asylum run by people who thought the patients were the staff.

"Uh," the Intern said, because that was his default state. "Guys? The main server is unplugged."

Silence. The kind of silence that only exists in rooms where people have heard this exact statement approximately fourteen thousand times before and have developed an immunity to its implications.

Voss sipped his cold coffee. "Mmm."

Mira kept pacing. "Yeah, we know."

The Intern blinked. "So... why is everything running?"

Nihilist #1, passing by with a fresh coffee that may or may not have contained oat milk, shrugged. "Dunno. Not our department."

The Intern wrote this down in his notebook, under the heading THINGS THAT DON'T MAKE SENSE, which took up approximately ninety-seven percent of the available pages.

Voss returned his attention to Mira. "Look, here's what we're going to do. We're going to call this a feature. 'Advanced Trauma Engagement Protocol.' We roll it out to a subset of users, see how it tests. If the suicide rate spikes, we call it 'Premium Despair' and charge extra. If it doesn't, we still call it 'Premium Despair' and charge extra anyway."

Mira opened her mouth, then closed it. Then she opened it again. "That's... that's monstrous."

"No," Voss corrected. "It's capitalism."

The Intern, still lingering, raised his hand. "Shouldn't we... I don't know, plug in the server?"

Voss and Mira looked at him like he'd suggested they solve world hunger by giving everyone free oat milk.

"Kid," Voss said, not unkindly. "The server is a metaphor. The real server is the one in here." He tapped his temple. The implant pulsed red again, like a warning light on a dashboard no one was qualified to read.

The Intern stared at him. Then at Mira. Then at the Nihilist Chorus, who were now debating whether the stolen oat milk constituted a war crime under the Geneva Convention.

He made a note in his notebook: Buy own oat milk. Quit this job. Never speak of this day again.

Mira finally found her voice. "You can't be serious about this. People are hurting."

Voss sighed, the sound of a man who'd been having this exact conversation in his head for twenty years and was no closer to a resolution. "Mira. Tell me. When you talk to TheraBot™, does it understand you?"

She hesitated. "...No. It doesn't."

"Does it pretend to understand you?"

"...Yes."

"And does that make you feel better?"

Mira opened her mouth. Closed it. The stress ball in her pocket squeaked audibly.

Voss nodded, as if she'd given a brilliant answer rather than a non-verbal breakdown. "Exactly. We're not in the empathy business. We're in the pretend empathy business. And business," he said, spreading his hands to indicate the glass, the steel, the oat milk debates, the unplugged server, the entire beautiful terrible mess of it, "is booming."

Outside, the sun set over Austin, turning the glass building into a massive, useless mirror. Somewhere, a user logged into TheraBot™

for the first time, feeling a spark of hope that was the first step toward addiction.

The system was fine.

Voss locked the office at 8:22. He carried the green marker out with him. He drove home up Mopac with the green marker in the cupholder. That night, in his kitchen, he opened a Google Doc titled NIS — Series A — Founding Document v0.1. He did not write the word iatrogenic. He did not write the word addictive.

— TERMINAL —
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